that Beijing was also seeking to expand its influence in Southeast Asia, Africa, and South America. Moreover, China wanted to displace the Soviet Union and lead the communist world.[118] Delhi's more immediate concern at the border was the period from 1966 to 1967, when China would complete its rail and road projects in Tibet and Nepal. It also worried about Beijing's "collusive aggressive effort" with Pakistan.[119]

Beyond the geopolitical threat China posed, Indian officials, too, were worried about losing the ideological battle to China—at home and abroad. They watched with concern Zhou's travels to many African and Asian countries, anxious that he would influence them against India.[120] Domestic developments added to India's sense of vulnerability, including Nehru's poor health after January 1964. Overall, an Indian commentator described a period of "crippling malaise of inaction and inertia" and "rudderlessness of the government" in India.[121]

Nehru's death in May 1964 did not change India's perception of China. A contemporary biographer noted that on China policy, the government of India's new prime minister Lal Bahadur Shastri, who had held various ministerial positions, was "disposed to show no quarter."[122] Addressing the nation when he took office, Shastri asserted, "China had wronged us … by her premeditated aggression against us." He noted that India had accepted a settlement on the lines that some nonaligned countries had proposed. Beijing could demonstrate any peaceful intentions it had by responding positively and ceasing its anti-India propaganda across Africa and Asia.[123]

India seemed vulnerable both at and within its borders. Contemporary observers expressed concern that India's democracy would not survive if there was "a massive external threat, which the civil government [was] incapable of meeting; and prolonged economic stagnation." At the time, both were plausible fears. The government admitted that the economic situation was "extremely grim." India's foreign exchange reserves were running low, import cuts were affecting industrial production, food was in short supply, inflation was rampant, and debt repayment deadlines lay on the horizon.[124] There was criticism from outside and within the Congress Party that the new prime minister was not doing enough. Senior party leader Kumaraswami (K.) Kamaraj warned that people would not have as much patience with Shastri's government as they had had with that of Nehru if it did not deliver. By spring 1965, Indian and foreign observers were